



Blip or headache: Afghanistan captain Rashid Khan's indifferent form with the ball in this year's IPL will be a cause of concern going into the T20 World Cup. EMMANUAL YOGINI

the top spots. The Rovman Powell-led side has decided on a batting-heavy squad, filled with plenty of hard-hitting all-rounders.

The West Indian squad includes power-hitters such as Powell, Johnson Charles, Shimron Hetmyer, Jason Holder, Shai Hope, Brandon King, Nicholas Pooran, Andre Russell, Sherfane Rutherford, and Romario Shepherd. The two-time T20 champion has a reputation for playing high-risk cricket. And given the inexperienced nature of the bowling line-up, the batters will be inclined to provide a cushion of extra runs for the Alzarri Joseph-led attack.

Playing Uganda and PNG in its first two games could provide an early advantage for the co-host,

which will then face New Zealand and Afghanistan in the last two group stage matches.

Why do PNG and Uganda pose a threat?

They are coming into the tournament with plenty of wins behind them, albeit against fellow Associate nations. A format as volatile as the T20 gives teams like PNG and Uganda a fair chance to showcase their skills and even stage an upset.

Papua New Guinea, also known as the Barramundis, won six out of its six games in regional finals to qualify, while Uganda, called the Cricket Cranes, won five. In the last 12 months, PNG has won 14 out of its 18 matches, while Uganda has won 32 of its 37 games.

PNG also comes with the experience of playing in the 2021 T20 World Cup. It nearly missed out on qualifying for the 2022 edition in Australia, finishing third in the global qualifiers. Uganda will have its cult hero, 43-year-old Frank Nsubuga,

who will be one of the oldest players in the tournament. Additionally, Alpesh Ramjani, who claimed the most wickets in T20I cricket last year among men (55), was nominated for the 2023 T20I Cricketer of the Year award.

Two teams that will qualify

New Zealand and the West Indies. Despite their overreliance on experience and conventional approach, the Black Caps certainly have the quality to make it to the next stage. West Indies, on the other hand, has plenty of big hitters, and if even half of them go hard, there's no stopping it.

Dark horse

Afghanistan is certainly going to be tough to beat, and it might even make it to the Super Eight stage. It now has plenty of experience and potential to compete with the world's best. Its players play in T20 leagues around the world and are skilled enough to handle the pressure in difficult situations.